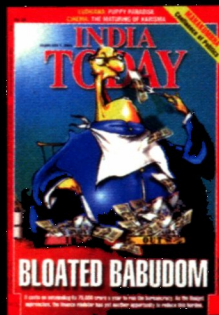
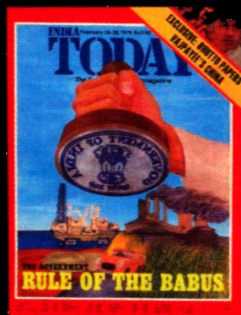


1979-2001



PELF BEFORE SERVICE

Babucracy was bloated then.
It's even more bloated now.

In February 1979, INDIA TODAY wrote, "The Indian Government is becoming, in the somewhat exaggerated words of a well-known industrialist, 'a sex maniac on a rampage, bent upon raping the whole country. Rapist or not, it is certainly the biggest monopolist'." With its tentacles spread over every area of Indian life, the Government brought with it a social condition—a culture of shabbiness and complacency, which reflected in its courtiers, the babus. "Thirty-one years after Independence,

the Indian Government, by its sheer monstrosity of size and force, has succeeded in corroding the independence of its people." Not much has changed since then. Corrupt babus have mastered the system to beat the rap and continue on plum posts. In February 2001, INDIA TODAY had this to say, "Civilian employees of the Central Government take away in pay a fifth of the revenues but give little in return, the changing expectations from the state and computerisation making most of them surplus."

The best government is that
which governs the least.

CHARAN SINGH

FORMER DEPUTY PRIME MINISTER, 1979

I STRADDLING AN ERA

From almost Machiavelli to ultimate leader, Indira Gandhi's image changed as much as India

From the fearless Durga, to the conniving Machiavelli, India has painted many images of Indira Gandhi. At the start of her political career, people looked up to her to carry forward the legacy of her father. But post-Emergency, she was never able to reclaim her past glory. In September 1980, according to an INDIA TODAY opinion poll, people had started to question the leadership abilities of Mrs Gandhi. The article stated, "Today, Mrs Gandhi's path is strewn with jagged splinters of broken promises and belied hopes. Like a gag in a silent movies, people expect a king to ride the stage in full regalia, but find instead a scrawny beggar limping." Almost two-and-half decades later, another opinion poll voted her as the best prime minister in the history of India. In August 2001, INDIA TODAY wrote, "There was another idiom of leadership that India looked up to, an idiom that never passed the test of squeamish respectability. It was amoral, unflinching, imperious and made a virtue of expediency, it was the idiom of ruthlessness that was personified by Indira Gandhi."

“As no miracle cure for India is possible, disillusionment will set in soon.”

ARUN SHOURIE

FORMER UNION MINISTER ON INDIRA GANDHI'S
DEFEAT IN THE GENERAL ELECTIONS, 1980

1980-2001

